THREE FINGER PLUCKING

Program

BLOCK 1 — directional plucking & the rake

01 One note

02 Two strings, eight notes

03 Two strings, four notes

04 Two strings, three notes

a = ring
m = middle
i = index

BLOCK 1

Program

Block 1 builds the three-finger plucking cycle and carries it across two strings. Every exercise uses one sequence, **a–m–i**, repeated in strict order and never reset. Three fingers do not divide evenly into four beats, so the cycle starts each bar on a different finger; each exercise is written to the length at which it realigns, and the repeat sign always returns you to **a**.

The two-string exercises add the **rake**. When you move from the A string back to the E string, the finger that played the last A-string note also plays the first E-string note, and the cycle continues from that finger. A rake is shown only by the repeated finger letter.

The fretting hand holds one shape throughout—C at the 8th fret of the E string, E at the 7th fret of the A string—so all of your attention stays on the plucking hand.

PIMA p = thumb (pulgar) · i = index (índice) · m = middle (medio) · a = ring (anular)

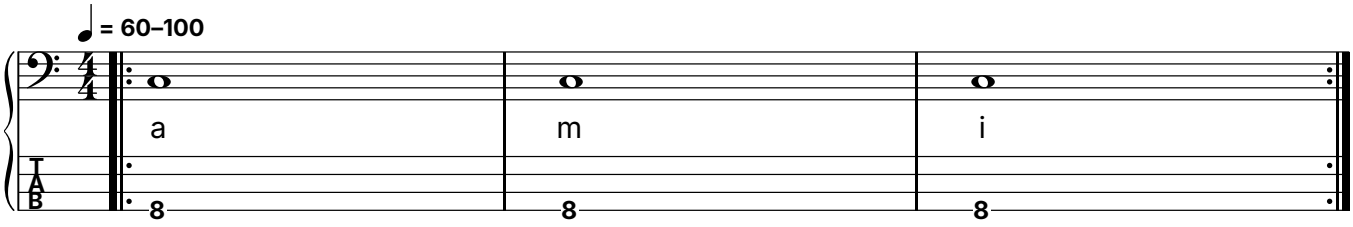
EXERCISE 1

Block I

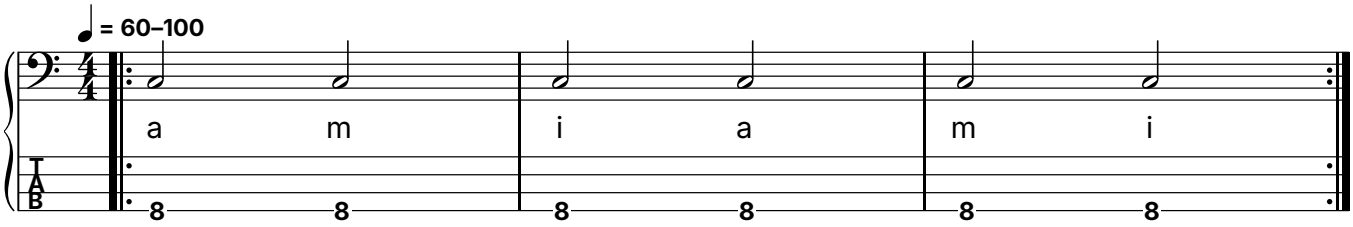
Exercise 1 sets the a–m–i cycle on a single note: C, 8th fret on the E string. Pluck in strict order and never reset. Against 4/4 the cycle returns to **a** on the downbeat every three bars, so each variation is a three-bar repeat. Move from whole notes to half notes to quarter notes, and raise the tempo only once quarter notes are even.

a = ring
m = middle
i = index

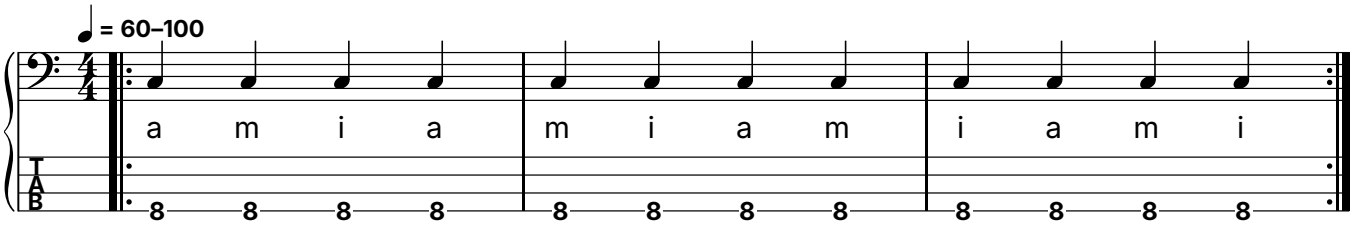
Variation #1: Whole Notes



Variation #2: Half Notes



Variation #3: Quarter Notes

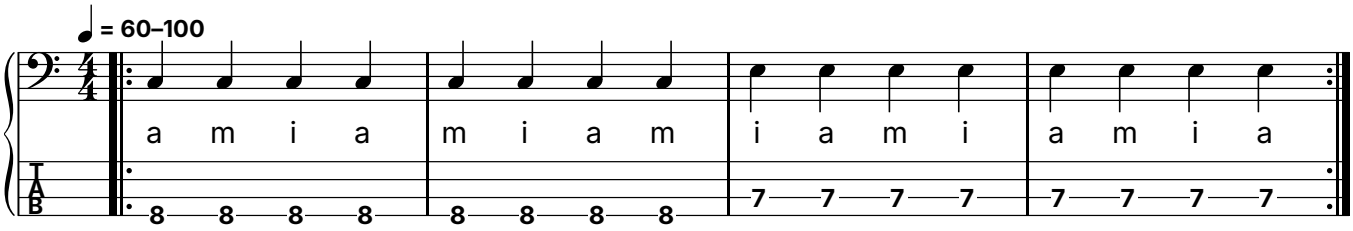


EXERCISE 2

Exercise 2 takes the cycle across two strings: two bars of C on the E string, then two bars of E on the A string. The cycle carries over the string change, so the A string leads off with **i**. On the return to the E string, **a** rakes: the ring finger plays the last A-string note and the first E-string note, and the pattern starts again. The 16-note phrase always lands on **a** at that point, so this exercise trains the ring-finger rake only.

a = ring
m = middle
i = index

Variation #1: Quarter Notes



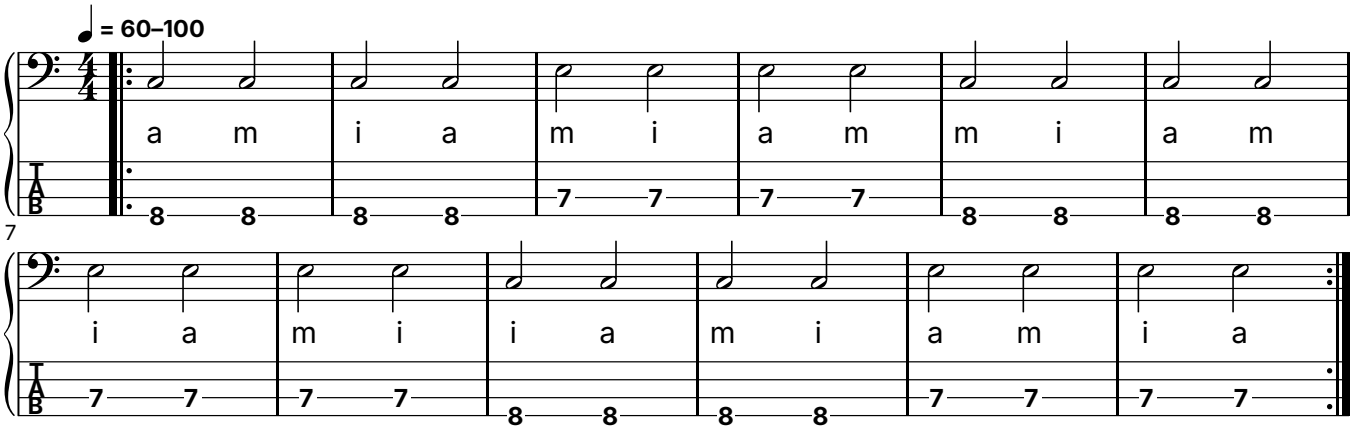
EXERCISE 3

Block I

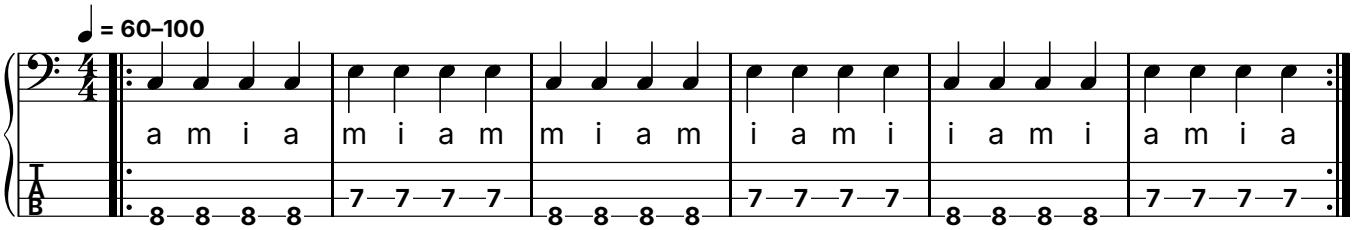
Exercise 3 uses the same two notes but changes string every four notes. The cycle no longer lines up with the string changes, so each pass leads off with a different finger and rakes with a different finger: **m**, then **i**, then **a**. The full cycle is six groups long and covers every rake and every E-to-A crossing. Learn it in half notes before moving to quarter notes.

a = ring
m = middle
i = index

Variation #1: Half Notes



Variation #2: Quarter Notes



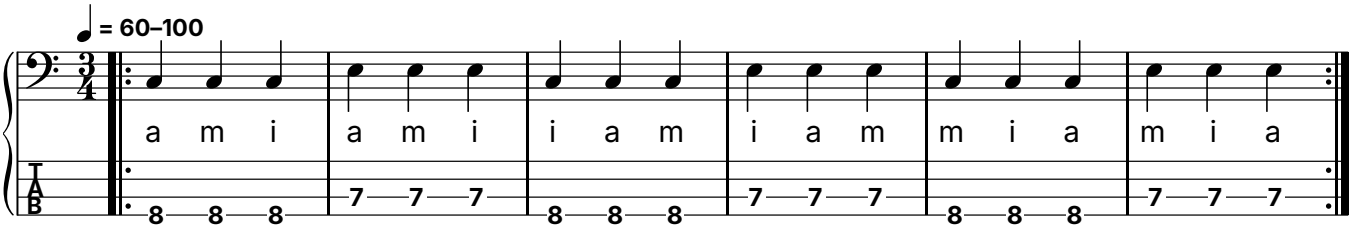
EXERCISE 4

Block I

Exercise 4 changes string every three notes. A group of three matches the length of the cycle, so each A-string group repeats the fingering of the E-string group before it, and the rake rotates through **i**, **m** and **a**. Variation #1 puts one string per bar in 3/4, so every string change falls on a downbeat. Variation #2 is the target: 12/8, the same rhythm as eighth-note triplets in 4/4. The cycle runs six beats, so it realigns with the barline every three bars.

a = ring
m = middle
i = index

Variation #1: Quarter Notes in 3/4



Variation #2: Triplets in 12/8

